E Lent 5 Grammar notes

Relative pronouns *"who…which…that…"*

- We already know that a PRONOUN is a word that stands in for another noun, to save it being constantly repeated. A RELATIVE PRONOUN is such a word, and **it is used to relate/link/join together two different ideas** in a neat and efficient way:

  - *Je connais une fille. Cette fille est jolie.*
    - *Je connais la fille QUI est jolie.*
  - *Elle a mangé une pizza. Je lui ai donné cette pizza.*
    - *Elle a mangé la pizza QUE je lui ai donnée.*

- The main words in French that function as RELATIVE PRONOUNS are **QUE, QUI** and **DONT**. It is **not** possible to say that "qui" = "who" and "que" = "that" etc. **You need to avoid falling into this trap**.

  - **QUI** is used when the "relative" is the SUBJECT of the verb, i.e. is doing the action

    La fille qui aime la musique, qui est là, qui s'est fait mal…

    QUE is used when the "relative" is the DIRECT OBJECT of the verb, i.e. is having the action done to it.

    La fille que j'aime, que j'ai vue, que je voudrais inviter

    DONT is used in the same way as QUE, but has a built in "**de**" that may be needed and cannot just be left at the end of the phrase

    La fille dont je parle (~~que je parle de~~), dont il rêve (~~qu'il rêve de~~)

- A simple way of checking is to make sure that QUI is used when a verb immediately follows and QUE/DONT is used when there is a word like "*je*" or a noun that follows.

- The three relative pronouns above link the information that follows them to the **SINGLE THING OR PERSON** that precedes the pronoun (i.e. la fille in all the above examples). Sometimes it is necessary to link the information that follows the relative pronoun to a **WHOLE IDEA, FACT or CLAUSE**. To achieve this, the same relative pronouns are used, but the word **CE** is used immediately in front of it.

  - *J'ai une radio dans ma chambre que j'aime* **(I like my ROOM)**

    J'ai une radio dans ma chambre, CE que j'aime **(I like having a radio in my room)**

    Tu as déjà lu le livre qui est ennuyeux **(the BOOK is boring)**

    Tu as déjà lu le livre, CE qui est ennuyeux **(it's a pain that you've already read…)**

REVISION: y / en

- You will recall that **"y" is an indirect object pronoun** and therefore:
    - is placed before a conjugated verb or dependent infinitive
    - does not cause any PDO agreement as it is INDIRECT
    - comes in penultimate position in the table of the order of pronouns
- It frequently means "there" and is also used to refer to THINGS only for verbs that involve the **preposition à** (see F Sum 7):
    - Je vais à Paris et je vais y rester deux mois
    - J'adore Paris et j'y pense tout le temps
- It is of course found in the idiom **"il y a".** This impersonal idiom **can of course be used in any tense** and these common and useful examples should be learned as they are a frequent source of difficulty. They all refer to the existence of something, "there is" and the verb **ÊTRE is never used**.

il y a	PRESENT	*there is/are*
il y avait	IMPERFECT (a non-event)	*there was/were (a lot of people)*
il y a eu	PERFECT (an event)	*there was/were (an accident)*
il y aura	FUTURE	*there will be*
il y aurait	CONDITIONAL	*there would be*
il doit y avoir	present + DEVOIR	*there must be*
il devrait y avoir	conditional + DEVOIR	*there ought to be*
il a dû y avoir	perfect + DEVOIR	*there must have been (a delay)*
il devait y avoir	imperfect + DEVOIR	*there must have been (lots to drink)*
il pourrait y avoir	conditional + POUVOIR	*there might be*

- **"EN" is an indirect object pronoun** also, and goes in the same place as "y" and causes no agreements.
- It frequently means **"of them"** and is also used to refer to THINGS only for verbs that involve the **preposition "de"** (see F Sum 7)
- It should be remembered that **any expression of quantity that does not specify what is being "counted"** needs to use "en" – *"combien EN veux-tu?"*